CAT DILR Set-Selection Scorecard & Decision Matrix

The 4-Minute Scanning Protocol, Clue-Density Scoring, Trap Identification & Time-Cap Management

1. The 4-Minute Scanning & Triage Protocol

How 99th-percentile CAT test-takers evaluate and rank all 4 DILR sets before solving a single question.

Triage Step	Time Allocated	Action Required	Elimination / Selection
Step 1: Rapid Inventory Scan	Minutes 0:00 - 1:30	Read intro blurb and question count for all 4 sets	Identify topic archetype (Arrangement, Network, Table, Game)
Step 2: Clue Density Audit	Minutes 1:30 - 3:00	Check whether clues are deterministic or conditional	Direct assignments = HIGH priority; "If X then Y" = LATER
Step 3: Question Independence Check	Minutes 3:00 - 4:00	Inspect the 5 questions linked to each set	Look for TITA questions and independent partial-credit Qs
Step 4: Final Rank Ordering	Minute 4:00	Commit to solving Set 1 -> Set 2 -> Set 3	Never change plan unless a fatal block is hit at 7-min mark

STRATEGIC PRINCIPLE: Golden Insight: In CAT DILR, solving 2 out of 4 sets with 100% accuracy guarantees 95+ percentile!

2. DILR Set Difficulty Scorecard: Rate Before You Solve

Assign a 1-to-5 score across 3 dimensions to calculate the Set Attractiveness Index (SAI).

Evaluation Parameter	Green Flag (Score = 3: Low	Yellow Flag (Score = 2:	Red Flag (Score = 1: High
Variable Count	2 to 3 variables (e.g. Name, City, Color)	4 variables with partial overlaps	5+ variables with dynamic movement
Clue Specificity	Definite statements ("A sits 2nd to left of B")	Relative constraints ("A arrived before B")	Negative / Conditional ("If A is odd, B is not blue")
Representation Familiarity	Standard 2D grid matrix or circular table	Venn diagram with 4 sets or scatter plot	Novel custom rules (complex board game, dice tournament)

STRATEGIC PRINCIPLE: Formula: Set Attractiveness Index = Variable Score + Clue Score + Representation Score (Max 9; start with highest SAI).

3. The 7-Minute Escape Hatch: When and How to Bail

The discipline to abandon a stubborn set saves your entire exam.

- Rule 1: Set a strict 7-minute timer for Table Setup. If you have not placed at least 40% of the definite entries by minute 7, STOP.
- Rule 2: Never fall into the Sunk Cost Fallacy. Spending 6 unproductive minutes is a minor setback; spending 18 minutes is exam suicide.
- Rule 3: Answer any obvious TITA or single-clue questions before leaving the set.
- Rule 4: Reset mentally for 20 seconds, take 3 deep breaths, and initiate your Second-Choice Set with clean focus.